



BRACKETS

Adding extra information without breaking the sentence

1 What is it?

Brackets (BRAK-its)

Brackets are a pair of punctuation marks, (), used to add extra information, an aside, or a clarification into a sentence. The sentence must still make complete sense if the words in brackets are removed.

(extra information) + sentence still makes sense without it

2 See it in action

Extra detail

"I had a cheese sandwich **(my favourite)** for lunch."

Ages

"My little brother **(seven)** is very noisy."

Dates

"World War Two **(1939–1945)** changed the world."

Percentages

"Cheese was the top choice **(73%)**."



You got this!

Try the removal test: take the bracketed words out completely. If the sentence still makes sense, you've used the brackets correctly.

3 More to know

End of sentence

"My dog Jake is on the sofa. **(He is asleep.)**"

Stage direction

"(Enter the **CARETAKER.**)"

FUN FACT

If a whole sentence sits inside brackets on its own, the full stop goes inside the brackets too — like (He is asleep.) — but if the brackets are only part of a bigger sentence, the full stop stays outside.

4 Why it's used

Brackets help: let a writer slot in a helpful aside, a clarifying detail, or a quick fact without derailing the main sentence — the reader can skip the bracketed part entirely and the sentence still works.

Brackets are also essential in play scripts, where they're used as stage directions to show what a character does, how a line is said, or when someone enters or leaves the stage.



Think about...

In a play script, brackets can show what a character does, how they say a line, or when they enter and exit — look out for all three.

5 Where you'll spot it

Mid-sentence asides

Extra information dropped into the middle of a sentence, like (which is my favourite) or (when using a parachute).

Stage directions

In play scripts, brackets show actions or feelings — (JIM looks through his bag.) or JIM: (angrily) What are you doing?

⚠ Watch out!

Always check by removing the bracketed words: if the sentence stops making sense without them, the brackets are being used wrongly. "My dog Jake (is asleep) on the sofa" fails this test, because without the brackets it reads "My dog Jake on the sofa" — the fix is "My dog Jake is lying (asleep) on the sofa."

6 Quick recap

Comes in pairs: ()

Sentence works without it

Also used for stage directions



Look here!

Brackets are a quick way to slot in an age, a date, or a percentage without needing a whole extra sentence.